

was the only board with just onboard Ethernet. Both the VIA-based boards came with Gigabit LAN—Gigabit LANs provide a pipeline 10 times larger for data transfers over a regular 100 base-T, and so can be very useful in offices where large files are transferred over the LAN, such as game development studios, architectural firms, etc. ASUS' A7N8X also had a proprietary Wi-Fi slot ready for plugging in the ASUS Wi-Fi kit.

Coming to I/O, the Gigabyte motherboard offers the maximum flexibility, with support for IDE RAID in all three modes—0, 1 and 0+1. The board also features SATA RAID for use in the future. Next in line was the board from MSI, with both IDE and SATA RAID, but with just two modes. The ASUS A7N8X doesn't support IDE RAID, but you do get SATA RAID. The ASUS A7V600 supports SATA ports, as opposed to the AOpen, which lacks this feature.



The ASUS A7N8X-Del out-did the competition, on both features and performance, to claim the Best Performance award

Package contents never get better than Gigabyte's generous offerings. You get a dual power supply daughter card, an external SATA adapter, brackets for Firewire, USB and sound, and loads of cables. ASUS and MSI were at their usual best, offering all that was needed to get their boards up and running. The ASUS A7V600 and the AOpen AK77-8X were meagrely bundled compared to the Gigabyte package.

Performance

The race for the performance crown was a close and exciting one, with the Gigabyte and MSI boards in a deadlock with the ASUS A7N8X, the pack leader, in most tests.

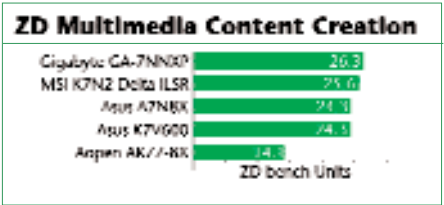
In the *Serious Sam 2* benchmark, ASUS' A7N8X emerged the clear winner, leaving the closest competitor behind by 9 fps, which is fairly good margin. The MSI and Gigabyte boards were quite in the same league, with the latter lagging by just a frame. Only at higher resolutions did the MSI board manage to come

on par with the ASUS A7N8X-Del. The ASUS A7V600 was left way back in the test at lower resolutions, but did manage to pull up to the competition at higher resolutions. However, the KT400-based AOpen board was simply unable to match the other boards, and it's clear that this chipset is ageing.

In the *UT 2003* benchmark, the ASUS A7N8X-Del again showed its dominance by packing in good frame rates. The competition wasn't far behind, and the Gigabyte GA-7NXXP was quite on par with the ASUS board. Following closely was MSI's K7N2 Delta. As we moved towards higher resolutions, the differences in scores reduced, and at 1600 x 1200, the Gigabyte was on par with the ASUS A7N8X. The ASUS A7V600 showed the same results - at lower resolutions, it could hardly match the nForce2-based boards, and at higher resolutions it did manage to get on par with them.

With *Quake III Arena*, the picture was completely different. MSI's K7N2 Delta took a good lead of 70 fps—around 16 per cent—from the second-best ASUS A7N8X, but the lead disappeared as the resolution scaled up. Finally, it was again ASUS and Gigabyte, respectively, taking the top slots. This time, the VIA chipset-based boards were way behind the nForce2-based boards.

Overall, in the gaming arena, ASUS A7N8X beat the others by a small margin. MSI was next-best in terms of overall game performance, beating the Gigabyte by just 0.2 units. The A7V600 from ASUS, based on the KT600, was equally good in the gaming performance tests. This board will



At a terrific price of just Rs 6,100, the ASUS A7V600 bags the Best Value award by offering great features and decent performance

Contact Details							
Brand	Intel	Jetway	Krypton	Mercury	MSI	SuperMicro	
Company	SES TECHLimited	Anirox Technolo-gies Ltd	Priya Ltd	Kobian India Ltd	Cyberstar Infocom Ltd	Netweb Technologies	
Tel no	022-26824141	022-28655282/83	022-56663100	080-5566624	080-2276986	011-26453486/26293486	
Fax	022-26824581	NA	022-56663199	080-5566625	080-2236781	011-26483586	
E-mail	kp@sesindia.com	aniroxby.vinay@ani-rox.com	priyabom@priya-group.com	india@kobian.com	narend@cyber-starin.net	sales@netwebindia.com	
Web site	www.intel.com	www.jetway.com	www.priyagroup.com	www.kobian.com	www.msi.com.tw	www.supermicro.com	
Brand	AOpen	ASUS	DFI	Gigabyte	HIS/Maxforce	ASRock	
Company	Xserve India Pvt Ltd	ASUSTek Computer	Zeta Technologies	Digi Giga Sytems Ltd	Maxtone Electronics	Tirupati Enterprises	Abacus Peripherals P. Ltd
Tel no	080-5572601	022-56926013	022-24102288	022-26526696	022-23016469	033-22423861	022-56923941
Fax	080-5572603	NA	022-24102277	022-56902210	022-23088545	033-25543255	022-56923946
E-mail	info@xserves.com	info_india@asus.c om.tw	sales@zetaindia.com	sales@dlink.co.in	meplsales@max-tone.com	asrock@tirupati.net	sandeep@abacus-peripherals.com
Web site	www.aopen.com	www.asus.com	www.dfi.com.tw	www.gigabyte.com.tw	www.hightech.com.hk	www.asrock.com	www.asrock.com